

VERSTAPPEN STRIKES BACK AT MONZA



Oscar Piastri continues to set the pace, but Max Verstappen's **record-breaking victory** at the Italian Grand Prix shows the title fight is not yet settled.

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For Max Verstappen, his form in the 2025 season has been a stark contrast to the dominance he made routine in recent years. With just two wins from the first 14 races — compared to nine by the same stage in 2023 and seven in 2024 — the defending champion knew a fifth crown would not come easy.

McLaren, led by a resurgent Oscar Piastri, pulled clear of the field in commanding fashion, leaving Verstappen stranded in third and more than 100 points adrift of the papaya-clad Australian at the summer break. Still, if Formula 1 history has shown anything — as in the unforgettable 2021 Abu Dhabi finale — it's that counting Verstappen out is never wise.

At Zandvoort, a circuit draped in orange for its hometown hero, celebrations were expected to mirror past years. Instead, the Dutch faithful watched another McLaren once again spoil the party. But one week later at Monza, Verstappen struck back, intervening in the McLaren duel to take victory in front of the tifosi — a result that reminded the paddock of his undeniable racecraft.

The gap to the leading McLaren driver is a hefty 96 points, but if recent races are any indicators, Piastri will be aware of the lurking threat in Verstappen — one he had successfully thwarted at Zandvoort.

A dual dream

The Australian delivered a flawless weekend, starting with a commanding pole position before converting it into his ninth career win and seventh victory of the season. In doing so, he achieved a rare feat: leading every lap, securing the fastest lap, and sealing victory for Formula 1's coveted 'Grand Slam' — McLaren's first since Mika Häkkinen's triumph at the 1998 Monaco Grand Prix.

For much of the race, the papaya team looked set for a dream one-two. Lando Norris, chasing Piastri, was poised to pounce should the opportunity arise. Verstappen, lurking in third, remained a constant threat — the type of scenario Piastri has grown increasingly accustomed to this season.

A different tyre strategy put Verstappen on the attack early. He briefly got ahead of Norris, only to be reeled back in within a few laps. The Briton, mirroring his teammate's calm precision, then closed the gap to Piastri in decent time.

But the unpredictable nature of